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The Nagarkhana
at Raigad

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FEATURES OF INDIAN FORTS

Wisdom of the ancient architects

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orts in India go back a long way, with even the cities of the Indus Valley civilisation having fortified walls.

The Yajurveda contains a classification of forts which is used by archaeologists studying them to this day. The art of fort planning is elaborated on in the Shilpa Shastra, which was the ancient handbook for craftsmen in India. Kautilya, better known as Chanakya, considered forts as a vital part of the kingdom in the Arthashastra, more so than the army, and advocated the building of fortifica-

tions around the edges of the kingdom. This advice was not followed though, and the forts were typically built at the heart of the kingdoms.

These forts were not meant only for defence, and were thoughtfully designed for people to live in them as well. The architects used all kinds of materials including stone, wood, mortar and glass in the construction. The stonemasons in particular were so delicate in their work that they could make stone carvings look like the designs on lace. The forts were often built up over several generations, with new features being added as and when they were required, such as towers to accommodate cannons, store rooms to house explosives, or loopholes through which muskets could be fired. As a result, many of these forts that pepper the Deccan Plateau have a hodgepodge of architectural styles.

Most of the forts mentioned here are located in Rajasthan, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh and Karnataka.

NAGARKHANA

This is one of those really interesting features that has nothing to do with the defence of the fortification, but rather for the spiritual benefit of the people living inside them. Above the entrances to forts, was a long, narrow chamber that was used specially as a dedicated space for musicians to perform their art. The name "nagarkhana" translates into English as music gallery, and that is exactly what this feature was. While the textbooks and reference books do not make this claim, the local guides say that music used to be performed at these nagarkhanas throughout the day and the night. The acoustics were designed in such a way that the